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Michael Abene

Michael Abene was born in New York City on July 2, 1942. He has performed with Clark Terry, Zoot Sims and Maynard Ferguson and has written arrangements for a lengthy list of jazz singers and ensembles. Michael is in constant demand as composer and clinician and currently teaches at the Manhattan School of Music.

Michael was interviewed in Toronto, Canada on January 11, 2003 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Toronto at the IAJE convention. And I'm very pleased to have Michael Abene with me today. We were just talking about the challenge of trying to show people what you do in 50 minutes.

MA: Yes. It's very interesting because I'm so used to doing two and three hour seminars. And the thing is when you do 50 minutes it's so — you know you talk about being confined, especially in the subject, in this instance of talking about writing for big band and symphony combined, which is a course that the late Manny Albam and I initiated at Manhattan School of Music and along with the help of Justin DeCioccio, who is the head of the jazz department there. So you're talking about quite a — it's not, you're not talking about all the writing for five horns or writing for big band, it's so much more involved. And just the questions, trying to answer one of those questions could take five or ten minutes.

MR: Plus isn't it, it would seem like you'd be getting questions that you can't really answer until you like work backwards and say first your deal with this before you can even deal with that.

MA: That's right. And the biggest question you get is, well obviously what you — how do you get your music played, which you know coming from someone like myself who is basically self taught and the way I did it was you know you write and you go out and throw yourself out there and try to hear it played by anybody. You know, who cares, as long as you're hearing something played. Obviously it's hard enough to sometimes deal with a trio or a big band, much less now you're suddenly dealing with an orchestral thing. But a lot of the students, a lot of the people who have access who are in universities who are even teachers or students or who have access to people at universities who can certainly, or music I should say music colleges, there's no excuse for not really killing yourself and making sure you can get these groups together. Or even write something for string quartet and see how that sounds. Just get the sound of everything in your head. So

and it's hard to answer those questions. It's like how am I going to become original? Oh okay, here's what you do, it's how you become an original.

MR: The days of people like Ellington having their own group to hear things immediately —

MA: That's gone, I mean that's gone. And the closest thing you have today, are the radio bands in Europe, mostly in Europe. And what you have in the United States the closest thing to that is the armed service bands and orchestras where you have — people are hired for X amount of weeks a year, you don't send in a sub you know. And certainly not in the armed service bands, but even the radio bands. You have to have, those people you send in for a sub if you're on a vacation or something, they have to be approved. So you can't just send, it's not like well it's a pick-up band. So you have the advantage of working with a band that is there 50 weeks a year, 48 weeks a year. So it really helps when you try to listen to your music, and that's for sure.

MR: When you were young were you one of those, let's say when you were a teenager, did you have a choice in your career or were you compelled to just go into music?

MA: I was compelled, not through my parents, but self-compelled. And I realized very young that I really wanted to be in music. And my whole family was basically in music. My father was very good, like a Freddie Green kind of guitar player. He had a big band, and his brothers all played. It was the Italian end so they were all barbers and string player or accordion. His father was an accordion player and string mandolin and everything. And my mother's side of the family, her brothers, you know one brother was a drummer, another brother sang, he married a woman who was a hell of a pianist, couldn't read a note of music but was one of those could hear something once and retentive, just bang, could play it. So it was always around. But I really enjoyed — I was actually writing and playing professionally at 15. I graduated high school early and I was playing with Don Ellis, the trumpet player, this was before he went to the west coast and started this big band playing more Indian-oriented time signatures. But we had a quartet in the city and I was playing there, did some writing for some bands around in the city area and I went to Manhattan School of Music at the time, which was then located on the East side of New York. It's not its present location which was the Juilliard School. And I went for about a year and a half. I got in as a composition major. I wrote a string quartet and a piano/clarinet sonata. Got into school to so called jazz education part of that time, late fifties, was really almost nonexistent. So while I was doing that I got a call from — I got to know Jaki Byard very well, a wonderful pianist, who was on Maynard's band at the time, and was also teaching — Don Ellis was studying some with Jaki. So Jaki asked me if I wanted to go on Maynard's band. And of course that was like the hot young band at the time for young players, the hot band. So I said sure. So I jumped on the band. I was

MR: What year was this?

MA: It's a good question. I think I joined at the end of '61. I think the first record I did it was Maynard '62 which was done at the end of '61. And I didn't have any charts. I think I might have had one or two charts on the first album. I don't even remember. I try to forget some of those charts.

MR: Was that "Three Little Foxes" that record?

MA: That was right after that. There was so many fox numbers in, I can think of "Fox Hunt," and there was all this fox thing going, seeping through the band over the years, you know, "Three Little Foxes," "Three Little Foxes," "Fox Hunt," more foxes, less foxes, red foxes.

MR: Willie Maiden? Was he in the band then?

MA: Yeah. Willie was there forever I think. He was there forever. And he went on to — he became basically I saw the straw boss of Kenton's band for a while. And it was a good scene. It was a very good scene.

MR: Let me just go back a little bit. Was your family, a strong Italian tradition? That kind of thing?

MA: Well this is kind of the sad part. My mother's parents spoke hardly any English, maybe none, I don't remember. And so when they were alive my sister and the family spoke Italian. As soon as they passed away then everybody forgot about speaking the language. My father's father spoke fluent English but he also obviously, he was born in, originally in Sicily and then came to New Orleans when my father was born so there's another whole Abene clan in New Orleans. And they pronounce it nice, they pronounce it Abanay or Ebeny. It's really lovely. But the bad part is I travel a lot in Italy doing workshops and concerts. And it's embarrassing not to know the language.

MR: Didn't a lot of the immigrants kind of want to get into the American culture as much as possible and not keep alive their — at least the language?

MA: Yeah. I should remember from what my father was telling me about his father. My mother's parents, they just came and they brought the tradition with them. My father's father, I think he became Americanized quite soon, right away almost. Because very rarely did I hear him speak Italian unless he wanted to curse at you or he didn't want you to find out something. But generally he was —

MR: Did any of the Italian melodies or that kind of music creep into your writing?

MA: I guess some of those melodies are so romantic, you know just so flowing and beautiful, yeah. Because the thing is they used to have parties and both families would get together and they'd party for two or three days. And not only play the tunes of the day — you know there was a big Benny Goodman influence at the time, so it was a lot of those kind

Tarantellas and all of those. So it was there, kind of floating around. It was about three years ago we did a record with this very good singer named Anita Gravine, and it's called "Jazz in the Italian Cinema." And we gathered up a bunch of the songs from Italian movies, you know we even used a couple of the melodies from "The Godfather" which were really lovely, from the Fellini movies, a lot of these things — had to have some English lyrics written so we got permission and recorded an album like that. And the melodies were just beautiful. We kind of put them in the jazz framework and they worked beautifully. But they're such gorgeous melodies. And I'm a big fan of the Fellini movies and DeSica movies and all that anyway. So it was just really, it was a lot of fun doing the record. It was really a lot of fun. But that, when you start doing those things you say these melodies are just absolutely gorgeous. Just absolutely gorgeous. You don't hear, it's not uptempo heaven at all, everything, which is nice. I mean you know. But everything is just beautifully, beautifully done.

MR: Was living in New York — this is probably a yes — a positive place to be for your craft?

MA: Well I was born in Brooklyn, New York and then when I was about I think 12 years old we moved out to Farmingdale, Long Island which is a very important part, because, and the only reason we moved is my sister and her family decided to move and the Italian thing is you know your kids go there, you got to go, you can't, it's not like you are oceans away. So we wound up on Long Island of course now what a drag, I'm trying to play. So I was in a school called Farmingdale High School and the band director was a man by the name of Marshall Brown who was probably one of the foremost beginning of the jazz educators along with people like Clem DeRosa and the John LaPortas and others on the east coast we're talking. And he had a high school band that we had John LaPorta and Lou Mucci who played lead trombone along with Gil Evans and Claude Thornhill, Marshall would get those guys in to tutor the band. And we'd have doctor — he would take some stock arrangements and doctor them up and change them and then we'd have LaPorta would write original stuff for the band. So we are doing jazz festivals and we're doing all the dances. So the school got bugged because we were getting notoriety as a jazz band. So the bottom line was — there was a combination — Marshall was fired and then he quit. Then he went on to start with George Wein and the Lorillards who were running the Newport Festival, the thing called the Newport Youth Band which was musicians audition from all over the greater area. You had to be a certain age. So basically in that band the drummer was Larry Rosen, the R of GRP Records, Eddie Gomez was the bassist and another wonderful bassist Herbie Moutin is one of the great bass teachers in L.A., Eddie Daniels, Ronnie Cuber a baritone player, myself, Jimmy Owens, a trumpet player. So I mean we had a hell of a band. And we had all the music

original, and I started writing for the band at one point. So it was a wonderful experience, also learning how to rehearse a band too. Again John LaPorta and Lou Mucci would come in and rehearse, tutor the band, in phrasing, so you talk about jazz education, my God. So to this day I feel I have, and Jimmy Owens, we've always discussed this, about how to rehearse a band and how to deal with students. We feel we've had an advantage you know, kind of making it fun and Marshall was brilliant in the sense that he knew what he could do, but he knew who to hire to do it good. And this is how, I mean Larry Rosen was the same at GRP, he realized he had, he could do a certain thing but he knew who to hire to make his company work. So and that to me is the smarts.

MR: Did your parents like this direction?

MA: That's funny. Well they liked the fact that I was playing the piano you know, but when I really started to get serious about it they got a little panicky. Because my father would play gigs, get home at four in the morning and open up the barber shop at six. So of course my mother said look, it's got to be this or that you know. So it was a little nerve wracking there for a minute, when I started to really get serious about it. Especially when I went on the road so young. So that was really — panic set in through the whole family, the whole family line. But it cooled out. They cooled out after a while. They saw I was serious, it wasn't like one of these well I've got nothing else to do so I'm going to go on the road for a little while.

MR: What was the road like at that time?

MA: Well it was funny. My big thing on the road was with Maynard's band. You know I didn't go through a lot of bands because I was so involved in the writing end of it. But with Maynard at the time it was funny. It was like two station wagons and a panel truck. And you'd have like basically — and it was a smaller band, it was like four reeds, two trombones, four trumpets including Maynard and three rhythm. So you'd have usually the band boy and one driver would be driving the panel truck and the rest of us would be split up into two station wagons. Which, if you've ever ridden with five or six guys in a station wagon, six or eight hundred miles, it's not — so to this day I can sleep bolt upright — in a train or car I can just sit bolt upright. It looks like I'm looking at you and I could be asleep. But the thing is, it was funny with Maynard because I was always not, never really happy with any of the records first of all. And just the recording quality, it was only one record I felt that the band really sounded good was a thing called the "Blues Roar." And we had enlarged the band at that, for that particular — it's Don Sebesky and I and Willie Maiden did the writing. But in the clubs, when we'd do clubs or concerts, it was wonderful because Maynard would just open up all the charts and we'd play like it was a small band. It would just, I mean some tunes were like 45 minutes, 50 minutes, and

always felt. So but I mean generally it was a good experience in that Maynard was a very good band leader, sometimes a little too lenient you know, but he was a great guy. Really a great guy. I have no complaints about that. A lot of good things happened.

MR: As a piano player, did you ever have to deal with lousy pianos?

MA: God, that's why I prefer writing. You just answered — and you just solved the riddle of my life. People say don't you miss playing. Yeah I miss playing. But I really love writing because, the first reason being that you know you guys can play your own horns, like the drummer plays his drums, the bass player, but then you're stuck with some of these pianos, they're just hideous. And to this day that's still kind of an occupational hazard for piano players too. But that's why, and the other thing is sometimes you play and you play a great solo, right? So the next night you go back and nobody even has any idea about how well you might have played the night before. It's up in the air someplace. At least if it's writing you write something, a good band, it's there to remind you if it's really good, and unfortunately if it's really bad too.

MR: Yeah. But if it's good it's going to sound good every time hopefully.

MA: Hopefully. At least you know your intentions. And it's going to played, let's put it that way.

MR: How do you determine — obviously it would change over the years — but what you get paid for your writing?

MA: Well that's funny. With Maynard's band — well let me just go back a step for a second. When I was on the Newport Youth Band we had I think it was an octet or a nonette with Ronnie Cuber, Eddie Gomez and guys. And I wrote this whole book. And when I got on Maynard's band I re-scored four or five of those things for the band: "Green Dolphin Street," "Whisper Not," "Airegin," some things that became good staple things for Maynard over the years. But with Maynard's band, you didn't get paid. You copied, you wrote, and you didn't really care because you figured you have a band that was playing your music. You got paid if it was recorded. And then the company paid something like a hundred bucks or something like that. So it wasn't a thrilling amount of money but the fact is you were getting your music played all the time. So at that point in time that's fine. Then you start realizing, as you start working for other bands in other situations that there's a price. You try — each arranger, from a Local, from a musician's point of view I believe — now my wife is good at this because she's really the manager of all this stuff. There is no such thing as an arranger's scale. There is an orchestration scale, and it's two different things. Okay? The arranger is the guy who sort of like puts — if I give you a sheet and I give you lead lines and say here, now French horns play here, trumpets play here, the orchestrator kind of takes that and fills in the missing — to me it's always been

one thing. Because and a lot of movie writers and a lot of guys don't do their own orchestrating.

MR: They write the skeleton kind of?

MA: The skeleton of it all, and then you give it to the orchestrator, and some of these orchestrators you never heard of, who are not only fabulous but that's also a very lucrative — the only bad part for me would be it's like being buried under something else you know. So I was never inclined to do that end of it. Over the years you establish a price for yourself basically. And there's no — a lot of times an arranger starting out, he says well how should I charge? I said well you know what you do? Go to your Local — if you're in New York go to Local 802, get what the orchestrator's scale is. Figure out that scale, what it is so at least when you bargain with somebody you have some idea, you know you don't just pull a number out of the hat. Because the guy will say how did you come to that price? And you say oops. So at least if you know say a chart at scale is $500. So you're asking $700, all right? So you have some kind of a gauge. So if he says well I can only pay you $150. So now you have to decide, and we've all done this, if you want to do that chart. How important is that chart for you to do? To this day, I don't care who the writer is, there are certain jobs you do that pay more — will pay your price and can afford to. Then there are some situations you really want to do a particular project and they just can't afford it. It's a budgetary thing. So you decide, oh it's not worth it. I don't want to do it. Or you say well it's a very important scene, it's a wonderful orchestra, a wonderful band and there's other far reaching things. So I mean I really feel that goes on to this day. Like I've done stuff for Liza Minelli over the years. So of course you're talking a whole other thing. Then when I did stuff for Mel Lewis for the Vanguard, now you know there's quite a difference. But certainly when Mel talked to me about it, sure man, love to do some stuff for the band. We didn't even talk about money. I mean now you're talking about something else now.

MR: Yeah, you're thinking about the people in that band playing your music for one thing.

MA: Yeah. Come on, there's no comparison. So for somebody to refuse that on the basis of well he's not paying me X amount, the guy's in the wrong business.

MR: Right. Certain things you do for the love of it, right?

MA: Oh man, to this day, certain orchestras I love writing for that I would do even though I know they can't always afford to pay my price. But I mean you figure my God. It opens up other doors too. It all depends, especially now we're getting a lot of composing commissions. Many composing commissions. Not only for band but orchestral, for big bands. Now that's important. You're getting your music out there and you're getting into another trend. Now a lot of these bands are for a symphony in Slovenia believe it or not. I

commissioned by the symphony to write a piece for the Slovenian Symphony and the big band. So being over there for one thing, letting them be aware that I was doing this sort of stuff, now the same thing almost in Denmark is happening. So I mean there's a lot of things that you can't — I can't remember the saying — but there's, you know you don't look at the moment you've got to look at where this thing is going. You know, where this project is going. It's an ego trip too, you say wow, I'm going to have all these guys playing my music and this audience listening to it. And it opens other doors for you.

MR: Is it easier for you to write when you have less choices to make, instrumentation wise, or when you have this huge possibility of a big band and an orchestra?

MA: It's a very good question. It's variable. It all depends. Some pieces fall into place a little easier. It's hard. Sometimes I've had more trouble figuring what to do with a band than I do with a full orchestra. Or vice versa. There's no set thing for me on it. And I'm generally working on two or three pieces at one time. So like if I run into a road block on one I stop and start working on this. And sometimes something will ring a bell working on this piece for this piece. And I get nervous when I'm only working on one piece at a time.

MR: Oh really.

MA: Yeah. And sometimes — I did this one thing for seven trombones for the Metropole Orchestra in the Netherlands. A wonderful orchestra, it was for a big trombone festival two years ago. And seven trombones plus the full orchestra which is about 70 musicians. So it was kind of a difficult piece. Each trombone player gave me an original and I had to write about an hour's piece of music locking all these things together. So I'm like sitting on — I know I have a deadline. I work better as the deadline gets closer. You know because if I had a year to write something I would be aah write a note, aah. Next thing I know it's like three months away, two months, then finally wham, something happens, I start clicking in. It kind of forces me, which some guys can work, like this piece for the Slovenia, not it's November 20 is the concert, next year. So I know right now there's no way I'm even thinking about it at this point, and that's generally because I'm trying to get these other things done. And at some point as it gets closer I have, I know who the strong soloists are, I know all the doubles so I know what I'm looking at and I know the band. So as things get a little closer, maybe two months away or three months away, I'll start to zero in on it. And you know my teaching at Manhattan School of Music is now up to like four days a week. It started off as one, then it was two, and I'm also — Jim McNeely and I are the music directors at the BMI Jazz Composers Workshop. So I live out of the city so I come into the city four days a week and I try to keep the weekends for writing. So it's like I'm really — there's some serious discipline going on. It doesn't look like it

MR: Do you have your own room at home?

MA: Yeah. I have an office down in the basement, converted, and that where both my and my wife's office area is. And I don't even write — I have a really nice Steinway grand upstairs in the living room which I hardly use. I use a Technics basic piano sound to write on, downstairs. And I write in longhand. I don't use the computer. I'm much faster writing longhand than I would be if I had to try to learn this whole computer system.

MR: Absolutely. There's something about writing notes which just is cool.

MA: Yesterday when I did the clinic I brought in all these — somebody says, "why don't you use Finale?" I said "well if I used Finale, I'd still be on my first chart."

MR: Yeah. You just tell them it's Finale but it's a special font you have.

MA: It's a special font I have. It's the Abene font.

MR: That's funny. When you get — let's suppose you get a commission to write for let's say a big band, and there's no guidance, there's no stipulations. You can write something totally original. Where does the initial idea come from for you?

MA: Well it happens both ways. Sometimes they will give you a specific — now say I want you to write a piece for trombone, or I want you to write a piece to feature it. Now one piece I'm working on now for the Metropole Orchestra again in the Netherlands is to feature their brass section. It's a closing piece for a big concert in Tilburg in the Netherlands in April. All right so now you know where your focus is particularly. Now what they want you to do, right now it's something that's going to be a through composer piece with either very little or no improvisation at all okay? Sometimes, generally when I'm working on a piece it will start off with rhythms in my head or if I think of the rhythms and I was telling the classes yesterday, I might be sitting on the train or at home or something or at the piano and just write some rhythm slashes down, just rhythms. And then maybe at some point try to get a melodic, some kind of melodic line to go with those rhythms, and it might not be scalular, it might be [scats] maybe a row, it's not a quote melodic approach in a sense. It might not always be. And the melody as you think of as a melody, like a piece I did for Dave Taylor, a bass trombonist for the symphony and big bands, it's based on two twelve-tone rows. And out of that the orchestra plays one — it's a whole thing — but there's no melody per se that you're going to sing along with. So I'll start off with rhythm ideas, add a melodic idea to it, and maybe harmonic structure if it calls for one. So it's kind of the rhythm comes first for me. Even if it's an existing piece, no matter what it is, I kind of think the rhythm. Even I think if it's about — I kind of think of a rhythmic thing and then fit a melodic line to some of those rhythmic ideas. Sometimes I do have a specific harmonic structure to start off with. But that's not as often, it's usually the reverse for me. Rhythm first. And I just start basically — again, it's

some kind of a thing will just start happening, start clicking. I mean it's not a Hollywood movie man. It does happen to me this way. It's like all of a sudden the strings and the band starts playing in the background.

MR: Okay so how do you remember this if you're on the train?

MA: Okay. If I can I'll scribble something down. Or I'll go home, as soon as I get home get to the piano right away and I'll work on scratch sheets. And I don't always finish a piece from beginning to end, I'll do X amount and then I'll actually get the score paper and start scoring that section. And while I'm writing that section I'm thinking of development — things in my head it starts development ideas start going down. So I'm doing this and all of a sudden I'm hearing something over here so I'll scribble that down. And then there's still a gaping hole here yet though. And a lot of times I'll work on two and three ideas for a section. I never accept the first — sometimes I'll go back to the first idea, but I always try to have an alternate, sometimes two or three alternate plans of attack. And I don't think I'm a fast writer. I guess I'm fast by some people's thoughts, I mean I had to when I was doing commercials, you'd have to write overnight which I hate doing.

MR: Right.

MA: You know when you're doing the world of commercials it's a whole other — let me not get into that folks.

MR: Well we have to talk about that a little bit. But Manny Albam told me a story about the pressure he was under to do the "West Side Story" record, like it was unbelievable. And you've probably had circumstances like that?

MA: A lot, a lot. The most pressures I've had, basically one of the things was usually when we write for Liza. That was always a lot of pressure. And we always had good writers: Sebesky, myself, Ralph Burns, Byers, you know it was great, it was like an education just hanging with those guys. But there was always a lot of pressure there because by the time you worked with Liza and you wrote the charts, she has already decided she wants to make changes all over the place. So you'd be running, go over here, you've got 80 bars over here you've got to go home tonight and write it overnight. And then you go back — oh you wanted to change something and you go back again. And there was one particular series she did where she normally would carry a twelve piece band but she was also doing symphony work too. So we had to do a chart for the twelve piece band, same chart for the symphony, and then another version of symphony including saxophones. So every time you fixed one piece you had to fix it for the other — and it was madness. It was insane. I want to tell you between I think Sebesky, we had every copyist in New York working the whole summer. This was a few years ago. And I mean it was lucrative for everybody but it was maddening. But that pressure I'm not crazy about. The other

commercial, it's always the night before. It's always the dates, you're writing all night because the date is at nine in the morning. And when I first started doing commercials I would do — this was in the sixties — we would do a spot in the morning. Then in the afternoon, before the spot in the afternoon I would be writing the spot for the morning, the next morning, and then we'd finish the spot after and I'd wind up writing the spot for the —

MR: So you were one ahead.

MA: Yeah one ahead.

MR: Or one behind.

MA: Or one behind. It always felt like I was one behind. But that was crazy.

MR: That's wild. And most of those were, at that time, a 60-second commercial was a reality.

MA: Oh yeah. 30's and 60's. I mean that was basically it. But you'd have so many meetings. I mean I had more meetings for the 30-second commercial than I've had for a record project. It was just nuts. But at the time the hip part about it is at the time that I was getting involved in the studio work it was the transition from one group of players, to the guys like a Steve Gadd and a Will Lees and Randy Brecker and George Youngs and all these, it was like Ronnie Cubers, Jim Pugh, Dave Taylors, we were like the new group of guys. It was kind of interesting, some of those sessions. But when I started The Beatles were still together so everything — when I started everything you wrote had to be like sort of a Beatles sound.

MR: Really?

MA: Yeah. That was the hot thing. The Rolling Stones and Beatles kind of thing and still Jackie Cain and Roy Kral we did commercials, we did sort of like that kind of a sound. That was still kind of in vogue, that kind of wordless thing. But the good thing about it, it was like a paid education as far as being a writer, an arranger/orchestrator. Because you'd be doing instrumentations that you would normally not be dealing with. But the best thing was I started writing a lot more for strings. That was the good part about it. But you'd one day be writing for like a big band, next day you'd be writing for four tubas and a piccolo or something. So there was no rhyme nor reason from commercial to commercial.

MR: Well how much input did you have like an ad agency would come to you and say we have to do an ad for toilet paper. Did they — was it your job to think of a melody?

MA: Okay, I worked in a music house with this guy who started a music production company so he would basically write the melodies, he would show them to me and maybe I'd fix something here and there. And then I would orchestrate. So yeah, when I went to this other music house, which the staff was J.J. Johnson, me and Tommy Newsom, which was

in charge of composing. Because the guy who ran the studio, he was the business end. He didn't do any actual writing so I would be composing more melodies. But you know again, they give you an outline or storyboard to work with and you'd start writing. Like you might write five or six little ditties. Go into the studio and just record some demos for them to listen to. And they'll say well I like this one.

MR: Okay. And you might have like a singer there, if it was going to be sung.

MA: Right. You'd hire a singer to come in, one of the studio singers would come in and do the demo, just maybe piano and voice that's all. In those days you could do just a piano and voice demo. You didn't have to do anything like elaborately produced as a demo. But the other good thing about it is that I got into scoring to film, post-scoring, which is a lot of fun. And I never really followed it up. I would love to have at some point in my life gotten into writing for movies. I did a lot of stuff for commercials. I did a T.V. movie, I did one small budget film years ago, but that was fun writing for strings and the post-scoring. That was, I'm saying, it's a paid education. And you have to look at it that way. Socially it was a lot of fun at the time because there was all these musicians that would hang out so the guys would all hang out at places, you'd see everybody, so that was fun. But it doesn't exist anymore in New York. I see guys who were my neighbors, I see them in Europe. You know Conrad Herwig, the trombone player, lives ten minutes from me, I never see him. Scofield lives right near me, never see him. Lewey Soloff lives right near me I never see him. Marvin Stamm lives two minutes from me and I never see him. You go to Europe, you see the cats. You go to LA and somebody's playing out there and you say, "hey, what's happening?" So that's the kind of sad part about it. There's no hanging. There's no place to hang anymore for the guys.

MR: Was there a club called Bradley's recently that just shut down?

MA: Yeah. It shut down unfortunately. I used to play there — when we moved out of the city a little over twenty years ago, and I lived about three blocks from Bradley's. I worked there many times. It was a wonderful place to play. And the last time I worked there was when I first moved out of the city. But that was ridiculous. I'd finish at two or three in the morning and drive to my house. I'd get home at like five in the morning and I said oh God. But that was a great room to play. A great room. I worked there with Michael Moore on bass, or George Mraz or Red Mitchell. So it was a lot of guys who came in, it was a great hang, it was a great hang.

MR: That's what — I think it was Ray Drummond was telling me that.

MA: That's right. Ray used to play there many times. And I think when Paul Desmond passed away he willed Bradley his piano. They had this beautiful Baldwin grand. And Bradley was like an amateur pianist. But in the will it said the only way he's getting the piano is if

MR: I see.

MA: So Paul had him. Because Paul used to hang there all the time. Alec Wilder, the songwriter, would hang out, Mingus would hang out there. But you'd look up you'd see like Jimmy Rowles, you'd see George Coleman, so it was the closest thing to like the legitimate jazz club. Well it was a jazz club.

MR: Just before we move on here, can you — any commercials that might ring a bell with us? I mean I know you've done many.

MA: Yeah but I haven't done them in well over 20, well 25 years. But I did do stuff with the original Fifth Dimension for Chevrolet or Jello or something. Did some stuff with Ella Fitzgerald for McDonald's was it? She did a whole thing but I did like a Basie kind of Ella thing. And then we did some Basie Joe Williams type things except we couldn't get Joe so we used Grady Tate, who is a hell of a singer. And I did — oh man I did a bunch of stuff for Michelob beer for Vic Damone was the singer on some of those. And in fact some of my arranging students I said just as a matter of course, in my garage I have boxes of reel to reels, which you don't even see anymore, my stuff is still on — that's how long ago it is. So I said for educational purposes I'm going to go out there and pick some of these things and get a reel to reel player from school — I hope, they might have them, they must them at the Manhattan School of Music — and play some of these things. Just from an orchestration standpoint, to look and hear. We always tried to make the things as musical as possible. You're working in a lot of different genres too. But that was sad. It was fun doing that stuff. Well it's like you do this stuff like the Ella Basie thing you'd have like Frank Wess, Frank Foster, you'd have like Joe Newman, Snooky Young, so no fools in that band. Steve Gadd, Grady would play drums, we'd have all the great players. So that was the fun part. But I should dust some of these things off and get the cobwebs off.

MR: Sometimes they still, they have this retro channel or something and they show some of the older commercials.

MA: Well in New York there's a station called TV Land I believe.

MR: Yeah, that's what I'm thinking of.

MA: And every once in a while you'll see these commercials from 20 and 30 and 40 years ago that's funny. The film is so grainy.

MR: Right. You've done a lot of accompanying of vocalists. Is there a special knack that you have to have for that.

MA: Yeah. Steel fortitude for one. Yeah I've sort of gotten away from a lot of it. I think playing for a singer is kind of interesting for a pianist, or an arranger, but especially for a pianist. Because I've learned a lot of tunes over the years and in any key. So for pianists,

to play them in a lot of keys. And so for that it was fun. Obviously for some singers I like playing for and dealing with more than others. But I learned, again, I learned a lot. And also I like writing for singers. I haven't done so much of that in a while. I did a record for Nnenna Freelon about three years ago called "Maiden Voyage" for Concord and we used different small groups. But generally, this wonderful singer, Jennifer Holliday, who did the original "Dream Girls" cast is a wonderful singer. We just did some symphony stuff for her for a concert in New York. But generally I've kind of shied away from that end of it. But I suggest to piano players, because a lot of the young piano players, you say a standard, they think of some 1970's tune by Wayne Shorter. That to them is a standard. You say no, you don't understand. It is a standard in a form but I'm talking about Gershwin, Harold Arlen. Because I've been doing very little of that kind of stuff, I've been doing much more through composed stuff. But I still have fun doing that with the right people. A singer friend of mine just did an album, a dedication to — oh God, isn't it awful, a wonderful singer too — she did Loch Lomond, isn't that awful I'm a total blank. Anyways the guys who were on the date — Maxine Sullivan — oh God excuse me. And it was kind of fun. I hadn't done that kind of music in years but I had guys who had played with her even. I did some gigs years ago, Warren Vache, Michael Hashim on saxophone, James Chirillo the guitarist, Chip Jackson on bass and Dennis Mackrel who was here with the Dizzy band. And it was just kind of a fun thing. But when you get the right players, playing that kind of music, it's fun. But it's like I haven't really just done that kind of a thing. But I enjoyed writing charts for singers. Right now I'm working on a project with Joe Lovano's wife, Judy Silvano, who is a very good singer. But Judy has always been involved with more free kind of singing and original music. This is an album of standards, although we're taking the standards very left of center. But it's not going to be like a lead sheet and we're going to count off and just play. And we've had one rehearsal with some of the guys. Right now Rufus Reid, Billy Hart, Ingrid Jensen is doing it, Dick Oatts on saxophone. So we're looking to record in May. But we're taking things kind of, using her voice as an instrument also beside the lyric end of it. I used to love playing for a singer by the name of Sylvia Sims. No chops at all, but swing and great ballads. I love playing ballads for singers more than anything. And also when piano players, a lot of piano players, when they're playing for singers I feel they play too much. A lot of this, a lot of single note. And I'd just rather play a chord and let it hang. Even when the singer is not singing, just hit a little splank in there, rather than fill up a lot of things. And the other thing I try — I've done a lot of workshops, in Europe believe it or not, not as a vocal coach but I certainly can teach phrasing and the main thing I find in most singers, they don't know how to choose keys. And they'll pick a key because the

pianist plays better in that key kind of a thing. And I'll say well look it, let's try this a half a step lower, a half a step higher. And they say wow, it feels much better.

MR: Wow. They must be appreciative of that.

MA: Do it in B, not B flat. Well I can't, the piano player can't play it. Well he's going to have to learn or get somebody who can basically. Because you're up there. Because the singer is straining. You say well — so that, believe it or not is a tremendous thing that nobody really thinks about, a lot of singers, they say well this key's fine. And so when I do these vocal workshops that's the first thing I do, what key do you do it in. Okay, let's try this key, try that key. And sometimes I'll do it with their accompanist. "I can't." So it's amazing. So I mean when I deal with vocalists I deal with it on that level.

MR: It's good for both of them. It makes the piano player work harder.

MA: Like I told my arranging class, even in the class, show no mercy. I mean you're there, you're putting your stuff out there on the line, but even as a writer you don't write down, you never write down. You just write. And it's the orchestra or band's job — my music is difficult play but a friend of mine, Jerry Dodgion, a wonderful saxophonist and also has one of the greatest attitudes in the world, and is also a wonderful writer. He writes like one chart a year but it's a good one, but he said your music is difficult, it's difficult to play, and then when you learn it it's great. It works. It lays great. But he said for some reason it's difficult to play after you learn it. You say well why? Fortunately you fall in the category of when you learn it it's fun to play but it's hard. It's hard music.

MR: Tell me about working with Joe Williams.

MA: I just did a couple of things with him. In fact it was at this club Buddy Rich had in New York called Buddy's Place. And I did a couple of things with Joe. I would have liked to have done more, we just couldn't connect with schedules. It was just impossible. But we did — one of the records I produced for GRP was a thing called "Happy Anniversary Charlie Brown."

MR: Sure I have that.

MA: So Joe did something, was it "A Little Birdie?" I can't remember.

MR: Yeah, you're right.

MA: So the day we were going to do it Joe was sick so he wasn't there in the studio. So it was Greg Phillinganes, who is a wonderful synth keyboard player. I forget who else, Al Aarons from Basie's band playing trumpet. I was playing another keyboard. I forget who the rest of the rhythm section was. And I wrote a chart, like horns, saxophone sounds and everything. So Joe comes in like a week later and boy he sounds great. So I get a call from John Levy, his manager, he says, "Joe wanted to see if he could use that chart, he's doing 'The Tonight Show.'" I said, "well I've got to tell you, that was all synth sounds,

yeah it's easy, the chart's there, I mean the chart's all written on scratch paper, we just used —" So I went and wrote this chart. It sounded exactly the same.

MR: Cool.

MA: But it was funny. And it did sound really terrific. You'd play that and you would have no idea it was like emulated saxophone sounds or brass sounds. Except for the live trumpet and live rhythm. But Joe said, "man, that was killing." So John said, "well can you do the chart?" "Yeah the chart's all there, you just have to write it out for the live horns, man, and you've got it.

MR: Yeah. Now I'm an orchestrator.

MA: So that was good. But I loved — Bobby Cranshaw got me involved with Joe in a couple of things. But he was fun to play behind. But Norman Simmons owned that gig. He owned that gig.

MR: Sure. Well Joe helped us actually get this whole project started actually.

MA: Oh I didn't know that. He was a great guy.

MR: He was a very good friend of ours.

MA: He was just a kind man, I felt, really kind.

MR: What's your feeling, you mentioned this tune that had all the synthesizers on it. What's your feeling about the electronic and the technology of today?

MA: I think when used in the right place I think it's terrificly enhancing. It can be really enhancing. When it first started happening, especially in the studio end of things, you know it really hurt the horn players more than anything else at first, in the studio. So you've got guys in the studio making $150,000 in a year as a sideman, was suddenly making $75,000 which in general as a musician still is not a bad amount of money. But when you're making $150,000 for twenty years, it really hurt. And what happened was a lot of these agency people said oh gee, we'll get a guy in a room like this or in that bathroom and write a piece of music on a synthesizer that sounds like 800 musicians. But then after a while they realized there's not really a lot of musical content going down here. It's a lot of sound but not a lot of musical content. So as in anything else the deadwood was kind of weeded out over the years, from like who really could do this. Guys like Rob Mounsey, who is an excellent musician; a guy like Greg Phillinganes who we just mentioned, the guys who were really good players, good musicians in the first place. And when they do stuff like that I love it. I mean you get guys that have a real good musical attitude. Rob Mounsey did a wonderful record with Eddie Daniels for GRP, now I can't think of the name of it now off the top of my head, where it was all synth oriented, and Eddie played clarinet and I can't think of the name of it now, but it's a hell of a record.

MA: Something like that. That's it, yeah. That's it. But I mean I love doing it. I mean I don't foresee using it — you know I'm trying to do this eleven piece band for like it feels like an eternity. I'm doing all the stuff for this orchestra and that orchestra and my wife has been bugging me. I've been wanting to put this eleven piece band together. So I've got like two charts written in three years. Not a great start. And it's been funny with me because I have gigs offered to me, and I have guys like Randy Brecker wants to do one, Dave Taylor, Danny Gottlieb on drums. It's like usually you get a book of music and then you're looking for gigs and guys. I've got guys and gigs but no music. So this is I'm thinking like come on.

MR: You better book a gig. See because you need to get panicked.

MA: I'm going to talk to Greg Carroll and Steve Baker about next year in New York, when I'm going to say listen I'm going to do this — that's going to force me into deadlines again, right? Now I'll have like 80 charts using that.

MR: And then the guys will call in sick.

MA: Right. In New York they better not.

MR: Oh man that's very interesting stuff. And you worked with Dave Grusin?

MA: Yeah well through Allegro and GRP. Which was fine. I mean that was a lot of good stuff. I mean it was a period I was coming out of a certain kind of a dead spot for years. And the first record I produced, I didn't do a lot of writing for the label, I did more producing than writing. The first record I produced was "Digital Duke" which won a Grammy for Mercer, which was fun because it had all those Ellington things and it was a lot of the guys — Louie Bellson and Norris Turney and Clark. So that was fun. And we did a lot of course the GRP style was more that kind of smooth jazz sort of thing so I did a number of those — Billy Cobham and Dave Valentin. But we also did the big bands. And the Christmas trilogy, we did three albums of Christmas music over the years, it was so great. Then the "Happy Anniversary Charlie Brown" sold terrific man. I think it sold one or two million copies which was nice. But the GRP stuff was a labor of love for Larry Rosen, to do something like that. And I mean budget-wise that was one of the high budgets for them. I can't tell you what it was, but everybody worked for what is called a favored nations — where everybody gets the same amount of bread no matter who you are. The arrangers and the players all worked for the same amount of bread. Otherwise you would never be able to get this album done. So that was nice. And those things keep moving on. And as a result of that the charts, my charts are all being published from that series of three CD's that we did. And I think couple of Mintzer's stuff. But we had guys like Mintzer, myself, Grusin, Vince Mendoza did something, Tom Scott and Russell Farante. So it was everybody connected with GRP basically, except for Mendoza, at the time.

MA: Yeah. I have been nominated a number of times. I mean it's fun to be nominated. Because somebody says well aren't you upset you didn't win. I say look it, if you go through that, the initial thing, you see there's like 95 names in an arranging category, and 150 names. And you get down to the final five, I say that's not bad. That's not bad. Because I have all these plaques along the house, nice plaques, covers up the hole in the wall kind of thing. But it's fun to be nominated. It really is fun to be nominated. But you know what it is when you see those names, it's like there's zillions of names they throw at you in the first place. So it's fine. And I think next year it's in New York which I always felt they should alternate years. So I think it's in New York next year, I'm not even sure.

MR: It would be this year, yeah.

MA: But that's nice. It's nice. It was great because GRP really they had a great promotional department too. So they did all the work. A lot of times you have to do it yourself a lot of times, to get it out there. But they had a great promotion department at the time.

MR: Do you ever have trouble with bad copyists?

MA: Oh yeah. Well my wife starting copying music out of desperation years ago because of that. She was in watercolors, she's a very good artist. And my scores seem to be — when I tried to write parts it was horrible. My penmanship went from clear score to like ugly parts. So she started copying. And she became one of the busier copyists in New York City. And she would do not only my stuff but she did a lot of stuff like for Sondheim like for Broadway and she would do a lot of those kind of things. She was working through an office that would do all the Broadway stuff, and plus recording dates. At home she would work on jingle dates that I had or record dates of my own, she would do that at home. And sometimes she'd have to give it out in the office because it was so much, like with Liza, you'd always have to have at least four guys ready for Liza because of so many changes and things going on. But she did it out of that and she did it for years. And then she taught our younger son how to hand copy but he copies off the Finale program. But he was copying stuff for Manny Albam and myself, and he just did some stuff for Scofield for something, I don't know what he did. And he did for Billy Taylor's book, he did a book and he had Justin do the illustrations for him in his book. You know Dick Sudhalter?

MR: Yes.

MA: Dick Sudhalter new book on Hoagy Carmichael. The music illustrations Justin copied for him. So I mean he's doing — right now he's copying some symphony stuff for me.

MR: Do you write your scores — are the individual instruments transposed?

MA: Yeah I write transposed scores. I try to teach students in my arranging class and also my

MR: Really.

MA: And it's really hard for me to read one. It's easy for me to read a transposed score.

MR: That's interesting.

MA: Yeah because I hear the instrument, and by the time my pencil gets to the paper it's already in the other key.

MR: So you can look down vertically down beat one of a certain measure.

MA: Yeah. And I'll find it a lot faster than I would if it was concert.

MR: Really.

MA: Yeah it's just that my feeling is that when you're writing in the key of the instrument you start hearing, concentrating on the sound of the instrument more. And also you see the way it actually lays on the horn.

MR: Yeah. You're going to avoid nasty—

MA: Because you can run into some serious problems, especially in the reeds, because the baritone, in concert score the baritone would be written in bass clef and the tenor parts are sometimes alternating between tenor — I mean treble and bass clefs. But I've run into more problems with the saxophones — you know they'll write a note and they'll say well that's concert note, right? And they'll say that doesn't exist on the alto saxophone. To write like a high C, concert. They'll say that note doesn't exist. Now if that was a transposed note then that note exists on the alto. So I mean there's a lot of mistakes like that happen. So I figure that can be avoided if you start putting it down the way it is on the paper. So I always try to initiate that. But a lot of the students now are working on the computer programs so I say but it's not really fair. You press an E flat button.

MR: Yeah.

MA: And so that's not the best way to learn how to do this.

MR: Plus the computer — oh I don't know maybe it does now.

MA: There's problems. Because I know my son when he copies sometimes he'll re-check stuff and it will lay out things in a rhythmic way if he's not careful it will kind of like do its own thing here, you know, take over the band.

MR: Right. It will tweak it wrong.

MA: Right. It's like don't do that. But I write my scores in longhand obviously.

MR: Don't you hate alto clef?

MA: Yeah, it's all the same to me at one point. The funniest thing is when I'm writing for strings for some reason the hardest instrument is the viola sometimes. And I'm thinking wait, now I can transpose like any instrument but why do I always sometimes have trouble with the viola? Years ago, one of the unsung heroes of jazz composing for me was Gary McFarland. And I wrote with Gary when he used to have a company called Sky

would conduct my session. But he wrote concert scores and it would drive me nuts when I had to answer a question, I'd look at the note I'd say wait — I'm hearing it in another key.

MR: Oh man that's funny.

MA: He says he can't write a transposed score. But also I tell students when you get to the point where you're having someone copy your music, if you give a copyist a transposed score — a concert score he's going to charge you fifty percent more scale. So I said if for no other reason, when you're in that position financially.

MR: Yeah well sometimes that gets people's attention.

MA: That gives you an incentive to write transposed scores. Gary would drive me nuts like that. That was a great scene, I did Grady Tate's first vocal album "Windmills of your Mind." I did one side and Gary did one side. And it's still one of Grady's favorite records. But that was a great association with Gary but nobody knows about him anymore.

MR: This is probably a hard question, but any musical disasters come to your mind that you've had?

MA: Well I'm good at — I'm always thinking of impending disaster when I finish a chart anyway. It's just sometimes like I guess there have been some times with certain artists, I don't know. The worst disaster I remember having was, and it was on a jingle date, it was a post score and it was like a 40 piece orchestra.

MR: Post score meaning?

MA: Meaning scoring to film, and so all your cues have to line up so when you're working on the movie, you know if someone picks up their cup of coffee and puts it down you want to catch that or you know, everything has to be a cue. And the cues are working great man, I'm in the office and I'm writing this chart, everything is falling beautifully into place. I show it to the guy who's job I'm doing it for, oh man, great. I do the score, I get in the studio, we run the thing down, record the track, the client loves the track. We play it back to film and the cues are off. I'm saying wait a second. This is not — so the editor, the filmmaker, he says "oh yeah listen, I had to move some frames around in this." I said, you know, you can't do that. You can't just move a frame here. You move a frame here, something gets off here and you move that. So by the time he was moving a frame here and a couple of frames here, everything was just enough off. So here I am thinking oh man. So everybody had to like look at the film again, move things over, now here's forty musicians sitting in the studio. This is going to have to be like a three-four bar. Now this is going to have to be a seven-four bar. And this — so that for me was one of the biggest disasters. I mean that's really a drag, I can't tell you. It's not like you're just changing a

this day first of all I'm panic stricken until I hear it for the first time. Because there's always things, like somebody says "how's the chart?" I say "it looks great on paper." So you go in, and I remember Manny Albam, we were doing something at school, at Manhattan, and he heard something, he had written something on a commission and rehearsing with the Manhattan School of Music big band. So he turned to me and he says "it didn't sound as strong as I thought it was, I'm going to have to fix that." I'm thinking gee, here's a guy that's not hesitant to say this ain't working. I mean this guy's been writing since dirt was born. And here he is more than happy to say hey, it's not — and that's great. That's the way I think all arrangers should feel about it. Because I always go in and I'm saying well if this ain't working I'm going to fix it. I'll be the first one to fix it. But I'm always panic stricken before I hear a chart for the first time. And the thing that's hard, when you do a lot of stuff for some of the European bands is that you may not always be there when they're rehearsing your chart. That's even worse. I mean it's so hard for me. I guess it's a form of control too. But you want to be there to hear the thing. God how is everything working. And they say oh everything is great. And sometimes the copyist will send you an e-mail ahead and say well just checking notes out. That's okay. Because I'll always try to scan my scores. Because sometimes a copyist will pick up maybe a score mistake too. My son has picked up score mistakes. Because when you're writing thousands of notes on something, something might be off center. It's hard. And a lot of times when we would do recording dates, like when we did the GRP stuff with the big band, my wife would hire a proofreader. Because one of the things that you want to do is not proofread your own stuff. Because you might miss something. So we would hire proofreaders to do that and it was obviously in the budget, we'd have it built into the budget.

MR: It's almost the same with text, with writing. It's hard to proof your own.

MA: In books. I mean one of the books I got for Christmas there was a couple of misspellings. Nothing major, but still, this is like a major, like Schirmer's Book Company or whatever, a major company. Maybe it wasn't Schirmer's. I don't want to get sued here. But yeah to this day I'm panic stricken. Even the stuff I'm working on I'm like really panicking about where I'm going to go with it next, how it's going to finish up, and I know on one of these things I might not be able to hear the stuff because it's going over to Europe and they're copying it there so then not only am I worried about how it's going to sound, am I going to worry about how the copying is going to be over there. Are they going to make copying mistakes? That's the way I feel about it. I don't know if everybody feels that way. But it certainly keeps you alert, I'll tell you that.

MR: Well do you ever take a vacation from it? I mean like really — when you have, I am not

MA: That's hard. My wife should be here to answer that one. Not really. It's very hard for me. Like when we do the workshops in Europe a lot of times we're gone from the middle of June to the middle of August in Europe. And we try to combine some like quote hang time in there. But still you're thinking about the next workshop. I probably think less — I don't say I don't entirely put it out of my head, I probably think less about things when I'm over in Europe. If I have a couple of days I probably think less. Because I know what's going on in the next workshop, and I know what I've got is pretty much set. So I try to like kind of, for me anyway, cool out. For me. Which is not generally somebody else's cooling out. But when I'm home, forget about it. There's no way. In fact when I'm home, people say well you're home, you're not so busy. I say when I'm home I'm a hundred times busier. Because when I'm in Europe first of all I don't — when I'm traveling I don't do any composing at all. After you're finished teaching or getting ready for concerts and rehearsing, the last thing you want to do is sit at a keyboard and write for ten or twelve hours. It's the last thing you want to do. If you're in these beautiful countries, you want to go hang and taste the food or the wines or whatever. The last thing you want to do is start writing. So the drag is when I get back though, it takes me a while to get back into that writing groove. That's the hard part for me. And I know I come back and I see all that score paper I left on the piano. I purposely don't touch anything. Whatever I've started, it's laying there for like two months. And I come back and I tell them if you clean me, she knows better, don't touch anything. And so now I try to start to find that groove again. Because it's a groove. You really are in a groove. Even though like I say I teach four days a week, and very rarely do I have time to write in those four days. But once that weekend comes I'm up like maybe at four or five in the morning and I'm hitting it. And you know like years ago when you first started playing or on the scene you get home at four or five in the morning. So I don't do that anymore. Now it's like more or less a normal day. If I'm off from school I'm up at four or five, maybe six. And then I'm writing all day. So maybe I'll stop for about an hour in the afternoon and cool out. So by eight or nine or ten o'clock I've been up like sixteen hours already man. I'm ready to pack it in. So then I'll do the same thing again. But that's the focus that it really takes to do that. You can't — even if I come up with two good bars I'm thrilled. So it's not the amount of music, it's trying to, hopefully, in your own head, trying to keep the quality at a high level.

MR: It sounds like your own personal standards are pretty high.

MA: Yeah. And again, nobody bats a thousand. Everybody has their moments, oh man I should have just done that. Even somebody said, "I heard a chart you did thirty years ago." I said, "I always wanted to go to another key over in that spot." I always wonder. I

even talk to me about the new stuff. And somebody'll say to me, like if I finish a chart yesterday and somebody'll say to me today, "well what were you thinking about?" I'll say I could not tell you now how I came to certain inclusions maybe yesterday. Maybe if I sit and think about it. But sometimes when you finish a piece, it's almost like your memory gets wiped for a minute. So sometimes when I go to do workshops and know I have to explain some music I will kind of go back to it and just listen to the recording of it and say okay, I've got to remind myself why I did this.

MR: Do the musical quote rules play a role in your writing?

MA: Well first of all I'm not really sure what the rules are in a sense.

MR: Well yeah.

MA: I know what you mean.

MR: You know what I mean.

MA: Certain things. But I think everybody should know some kind of basic rules and then set out to break them. Because I've had like a seminar in my house with some really good professional writers and the point is they learned the rules but they never learned how to break them. So my purpose at that point would say well how do we break these rules? How do we do this and what can you tell us to get away from these things? Because you can write something very correct and it'll sound boring as hell. And then you could write all kinds of just kind of stuff that really you're breaking every rule in the world and it sounds great. Look at Gil Evans or Duke or any of those guys. So I mean George Russell is one of my favorite writers. So I mean there's a lot of it that's just up to you. It's like in the BMI class somebody asked Jim McNeely and I "how do you be original?" "What do you mean?" Well first of all everybody starts off by stealing. McNeely says "you start off by stealing." You don't maybe say it in those terms but you know it's the influences. And then you take all these influences from various — whether you're a player or a writer — and you kind of hopefully it fuses into something of your own at some point in time. But you don't start off — you know I've listened to not only classical music but somebody says "who are your favorite writers?" I don't know man there was Benny Carter, there's Edgar Sampson, there's Jimmy Mundy, there's Fletcher Henderson. I mean start there and keep going. There's the George Russells, there's — I mean this is endless. But my favorite writers might be Ellington, Strayhorn, Gil Evans and George Russell. But there's so many things before this. You know everybody draws from other things. Gil Evans drew from a lot of people. Duke drew from other people. But he fused. It's a matter of like shaping something into something, hopefully. It doesn't happen right away. Obviously it's not like well I'm 32 years old or I'm 19 years old and I'm not an original so I'm leaving town. But you try to do everything. But when people have a question like

basically what you do in a way. And then you hopefully steal enough and maybe fuse this into something of your own hopefully.

MR: Do you ever have trouble thinking of titles?

MA: That's a great question. Yeah I have a major problem sometimes thinking of titles. Sometimes I'll be sitting there and like I'll have a list of some titles I'm trying to call this brass piece. And I'm thinking oh man I'll finish the chart and I won't have a title. That's my biggest worry. I'll say oh man I cannot think of titles. I'm the worst at thinking of titles.

MR: Well you know sometimes it'll put a spin on it that you don't really want.

MA: I know. Sometimes I'll write, like a facetious kind of title, but then I'll say wait a second. They're going to think it's a joke, and I don't want — Because I had a title for this one, for this piece now, because it's the brasses and I had certain titles, and I think naa — I don't want to make it sound like it's a funny tune or something, a funny piece. So I've got all these — but it's the most worrisome thing to me. I'm worried enough about the piece itself. And then I've got to say oh my God, I've got to hire somebody just to come up with titles. Hire a title guy.

MR: Maybe even to just do the Opus thing.

MA: Yeah. Opus Number One.

MR: Who was the — Anthony Braxton, you know, his songs, he'd be like this is Song 106D.

MA: That's great.

MR: Have you seen his? Or he had schematics.

MA: Oh you're kidding.

MR: Really on his albums he would have like these weird schematics. That was the title.

MA: That's great. That's not a bad idea. I've got to figure that. Because I'm sitting there and I'm going nuts man. Like this title, it's called "To Think Two Thoughts," it was a piece for symphony. And then the piece for Dave Taylor I finally came up with — we went through, it was a very kind of out piece but there was a middle section he wanted kind of a New Orleansish kind of thing. But it's a New Orleansish thing, it's like an atonal New Orleans blues. So I called it "Heritage New, Old and Then Some." Because I figured here's the one part of the heritage — but it takes me a while man. I'll tell you. I'm the worst at titles. I'm sorry about that one.

MR: No, no, it's true. You don't want to make it an inside joke. Because some people get it, some people won't.

MA: That's the thing. You don't want that. You don't want to do that.

MR: You know it's funny, music doesn't always have to mean something.

MA: Yeah. Some people have a tendency to make their titles so ultra-serious too. And another

students, or even professional-level band, to me the music is very serious. But at the same level it's fun. So I will not — I mean I try to make it fun for them. And it kind of it's equal to me. Like some people — well if the guy's making it fun then it can't be too good, the music. Some people have that — they think well he's having too much of a good time therefore his music can't be that serious. Which is absurd. Because if I'm being a sideman, knowing how you want to be treated, you don't want to be spoken down to, you don't want to be insulted. So when I worked with orchestras, I mean I have a lot of fun with them and I tell jokes, I'll make funny remarks not only about certain things about the guys that I like, but also about myself. And they love that. Because it's not like I'm always making fun of you but don't you make fun of me. It's like if I give it to you, you can certainly give it back to me. But we're still talking like, we're not talking hitting you under the belt or anything like that. That's just me having fun with the guys. And I really feel it helps to play the music better too. Because it takes their mind off a little bit of how difficult the music is. You know if you come in with the ultra-serious "now gentleman this is a very serious piece of music and I expect you to be serious." Come on.

MR: Right.

MA: To me, you don't' need to do that. The music should be fun, no matter how serious it is. So I mean I always like to convey that, and working with students too. Especially with students. Even like I said the professional, it's like that. You come in and they respect your music. So now you've got to have them respect you, because if you're conducting an orchestra or band, they're not going to respond to you, believe me, as a conductor or as personality. They might like playing the music, and some of these bands might say well [gap in tape] is a real drag, we'd rather not have him back. So I mean I'm not saying — and I agree with that. It's a shame because there's some guys that write some great music, and some guys that write not-so-great music but they're fun — they make the music fun. I like the music to be fun but it's serious to me. It's really serious. I hate laughter when I'm writing. Or I'm giggling, I'm chuckling, but no hysteria yet. The only hysteria is the panic waiting to hear the music.

MR: Well it's been serious fun talking with you today, I want to tell you. It's been really a great conversation and I appreciate it. And I hope you don't get too panicked with your upcoming project. So thanks for your time today.

MA: Thank you, Monk. Thank you very much, really. Thank you. Thanks.